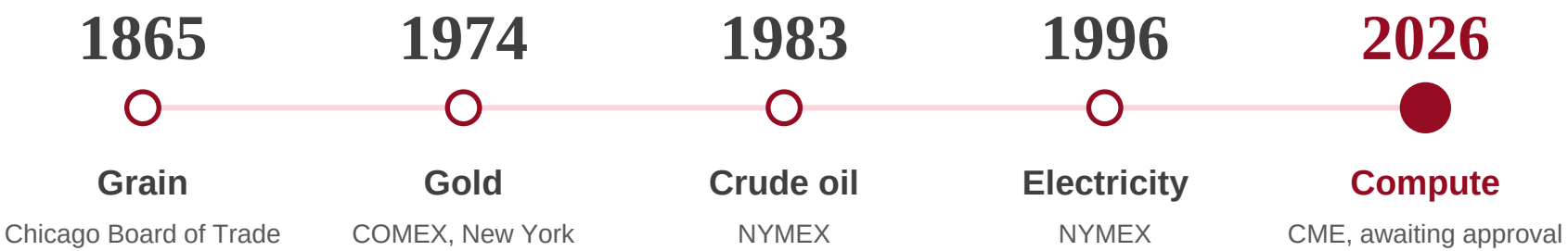


Compute Futures

By Miles Hapgood

From Grain to GPUs

FIRST FUTURES CONTRACTS



Year of the first futures contract in each commodity. Compute futures are pending CFTC review.

What Is Compute?

BUCTC
BOSTON UNIVERSITY COMMODITIES TRADING CLUB

DEFINITION

Compute is the processing power that trains and runs AI models. Companies buy it by renting time on **GPUs**, specialised chips made mainly by Nvidia.

THE UNIT

1 GPU-hour

One chip, rented for one hour

THE CHIPS

H100 & B200

Nvidia's Hopper and Blackwell GPUs

CLOSEST COMMODITY

Electricity

Can't be stored; CME lists it under power

Why Hedge Compute?

BUCTC
BOSTON UNIVERSITY COMMODITIES TRADING CLUB

THE PROBLEM

There has been no public price for compute. Rental deals are negotiated privately, so two buyers can pay very different prices for the same GPUs.

THE CRASH

$8 → $2

H100 rental per hour, 2023 vs late-2025 marketplace rates

THE REBOUND

+56%

One-year H100 rental rate, Oct 2025 to Mar 2026

Sources: Silicon Data, H100 rental price history (2023–25) and GPU futures research (2026).

How Do Compute Futures Work?

	CME compute futures
Exchange	NYMEX, part of CME Group
Tracks	Silicon Data's H100 and B200 GPU rental price indexes
Contract size	730 GPU-hours, about one month of one GPU
Priced in	Dollars per GPU-hour (a $0.01 move = $7.30 per contract)
Settlement	Cash, against the average index price over the month
Months listed	36 consecutive months
Status	**Delayed: CFTC review extended to 9 Nov 2026**

EXAMPLE

Index at $2.50 → one contract is worth **$1,825**

WHY 730 HOURS?

24 hours × 365 days ÷ 12 months = **730**

Sources: CME Group contract filing to the CFTC (11 Aug 2026); CFTC review extension (21 Sep 2026).

Who Hedges Compute?

	Short hedge	Long hedge
Who	GPU owners: neoclouds, data centres	GPU renters: AI labs, start-ups, enterprises
Physical position	Own GPUs, will rent them out	Need GPUs, will rent them later
Afraid of	**Falling rental prices**	**Rising rental prices**
The hedge	**Sell compute futures**	**Buy compute futures**
Example	Neocloud locks in next year's rental income	AI start-up fixes the cost of a training run
Natural fits	**CoreWeave**	**OpenAI**

Worked Example

THE SETUP

01 Neocloud owns 1,000 H100s and rents them out by the hour

02 Sells 1,000 November H100 futures at $2.50 per GPU-hour

03 End of November: rents at the market price, futures settle in cash

THE OUTCOME

	Falls to $2.00	Rises to $3.00
Rental income	$1,460,000	$2,190,000
Futures P&L	+$365,000	−$365,000
Total	$1,825,000	$1,825,000

UNHEDGED

$1.46m–$2.19m

but

HEDGED

$1.825m

Prices are November averages. Assumes every GPU is rented all month at the index price.

The Exchange Race

Exchange	Index	What it covers	Status
CME (NYMEX)	Silicon Data	H100 and B200 rental prices	**Delayed: CFTC review to 9 Nov**
ICE	Ornn	H100, H200, B200 and RTX 5090	Announced May 2026
ICE	NATIVX	Compute priced alongside energy costs	Announced Jul 2026
Nodal Exchange	Compute Desk	Hopper and Blackwell GPUs	Announced Sep 2026
Architect (Bermuda)	Ornn	Perpetual futures on GPUs and memory	Live offshore

SILICON DATA INDEX (CME)

On-demand rental prices at neoclouds, excluding the big hyperscalers

ORNN INDEX (ICE)

Built only from trades that actually happened

Sources: exchange announcements (May–Sep 2026); CME product page; Finance Magnates on Architect (Aug 2026).

Will It Work?

THE CASE FOR

A huge, volatile market

→ **$765bn** of AI spending forecast in 2026
→ Rental prices swung **over 50%** in months
→ Lenders need a price for **GPU collateral**
→ **CME, ICE and Nodal** all racing to list

THE CASE AGAINST

Hard to standardise

→ New chip generation every **18–24 months**
→ No two GPU-hours are **quite the same**
→ CFTC delayed CME over **manipulation risk**
→ Enron tried this with **bandwidth** in 2000

WHAT TO WATCH

9 November 2026: the CFTC's extended review of CME's contracts ends

Sources: Goldman Sachs AI capex forecast; Silicon Data; CFTC review extension (Sep 2026).